

# BUT...TORRENT

## TORRENTS HAVE BEEN BLOCKED, WHICH IS OK FOR ILLEGAL STUFF, BUT WHAT ABOUT LEGAL TORRENT DOWNLOADS?

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iracy hurts the people who create content, which is so good that you're willing to pirate it just to watch it.

That's just crazy, right? Now we may feel strongly about piracy, but there's something else we feel even more strongly about, and that's censorship. While we're all for stopping cyber crime, we're never going to support the curbing of rights in order to do that. It is your right to use P2P networks such as torrent, and use it you shall, thanks to this article.

The government wants to block illegal content, and has instructed ISPs to do that, but we don't think blocking off a technology as a whole is warranted at all. We refuse to be treated as guilty until proven innocent, and we want to be able to use P2P for legal file sharing. Honestly, we suspect the government isn't interested in blocking the entire technology either, and we're pretty sure you won't be prosecuted for using P2P for legal file sharing.

### HOW DO TORRENTS WORK?

In order to be able to know how torrents are blocked, you first need to know how they work.

When you try to download a file normally online, you usually click on a link or download button. This leads to your web browser asking the remote server (the computer on which the file is hosted) to send a copy of the file to your machine. This transfer is handed by File Transfer Protocol (FTP) or Hyper Text Transfer Protocol (HTTP). Now, the transfer speed, or more popularly, the download speed will be affected by quite a few factors – such as server load, protocol type and number of simultaneous ongoing downloads of the file. Almost all of this is different in the case of peer-to-peer file sharing.

First of all, there is a dedicated software client that takes your request and searches other computers just like yours for the file or a portion of the file that has been requested. These computers also have similar P2P software running in order to be able to understand the request. Once such computers are found, your computer starts downloading the file. BitTorrent or torrents in general take this one step further by offloading the tracking of other computers to a central server called a tracker. And torrents work on a tit-for-tat basis, meaning the more of the file you upload, the better downloading bandwidth you get. Also, the file is downloaded in multiple pieces

from multiple machines to avoid bottlenecks and low speeds.

These pieces are then joined by the software to give you the file. However, your job is not done yet. If you keep uploading even after your file is completely downloaded, you get a good preference in the P2P system.

### THE CHESHIRE KAT

Much like the mysterious feline character in Alice in Wonderland, one of the biggest torrent networks in the world recently vanished into thin air. KAT (short for KickAss Torrents) operated under multiple domain names, all of which were seized by US authorities recently, along with the arrest of the person who was allegedly running the site. KAT was the Netflix of the torrent world, because it had a vibrant community that always reported fake uploads and rated audio and video quality accurately. It was also a good place to find esoteric stuff, which may not have been super popular, and thus hard to find.

It's just a site, though, and uploaders have just moved on to other sites, which are now getting a lot of traffic that they just didn't before. Sites such as demonoid, GloTorrents and 1337x are seeing an increase in the number of seeders and uploaders for all their torrents and all three of